

25 August 2026

Dear Hiring Manager,

Bringing Star Wars, Mickey & Friends and Marvel to fans across MENA through a best-in-class Hardlines Toys portfolio is exactly the kind of category-and-commercial challenge I love — so the Category Manager – Toys (MENA) role stood out immediately. Category strategy, partnership development, joint business planning and contract negotiation across consumer products are the spine of my career, I'm Dubai-based with fluency across GCC/MENA markets, and I'd bring genuine energy to growing beloved franchises in the region.

My background is squarely in category and commercial roles within consumer products. At Alibaba's Miravia I led category expansion as PIC Fragrances — building relationships with new and existing partners, onboarding 30+ stores in two months (including the official distributors of major Arabian and oud houses), and managing 42 accounts against P&L targets to grow GMV +30% QoQ. Before that I ran Category Planning for chocolate at Mondelez (sell-in/sell-out, promotional effectiveness, NPD). Today at DoFreeze I own category and go-to-market strategy across 50+ markets, lead joint business planning and contract negotiation with distributors and modern-trade/quick-commerce partners, and turn forecasting and market data into working plans — the annual-operating-plan, forecasting and financial-acumen work this role calls for. I also bring a good eye for digital, social and brick-and-mortar marketing, plus an Inditex (Massimo Dutti) retail and visual-merchandising foundation.

I'll be transparent about the two honest gaps: my categories have been beauty, fragrances, fashion and FMCG rather than toys, and I haven't worked inside a brand-licensing model — but the transferable craft (category strategy, licensee/partner development, joint business planning, regional negotiation, forecasting and consumer-products commercial acumen) is precisely what I do, and I ramp fast on new categories. My English is business-level C1 (I don't speak Arabic, noted as preferable), and I add an early-adopter edge in generative AI (Claude/GPT) that accelerates market research, category insight and reporting — useful for spotting scalable, high-impact opportunities quickly in a fast-moving MENA market.

I'd welcome the chance to talk through how I'd approach the first 90 days — mapping the MENA Hardlines Toys landscape, prioritising the highest-impact licensee partnerships and building an annual plan with clear forecasts and joint objectives. I'm already based in Dubai and available for on-site work, I bring real category and commercial depth in consumer products, and I'd be genuinely excited to help bring Disney magic to fans across the region. Thank you for considering my application.

Best regards,

Paula De Francisco Pérez

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